States' Graduation Policies for Students with Significant Cognitive Disabilities Who Participate in Alternate Assessments

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Graduation rates and requirements for earning a regular diploma are of increasing interest as states seek to ensure that all students are college- and career-ready when they leave school with a diploma. This study focuses on state graduation options for students with significant cognitive disabilities who take states' alternate assessments on alternate achievement standards (AA-AAS).

Research Questions

- Can students with significant cognitive disabilities participating in AA-AAS earn a regular diploma?
- If they can, what are the requirements? Do the requirements differ across states? Do the requirements differ from other students?
- Are there other end-of-school documents students with significant cognitive disabilities can earn? What is required to earn them?

Method

- NCEO staff searched for information on state department of education websites.
- The information was compiled and summarized.
- State directors of special education were sent a verification form with findings.
- A total of 47 verification responses were obtained from the 50 states (94%).
- States allowing students in AA-AAS to receive a regular diploma were assigned a category in Table 1. If a state fit in two categories, it was put in the category "farthest away" from the criterion used for all students.

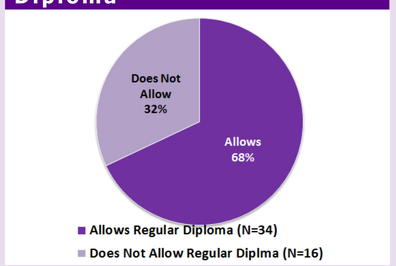
Table 1: Prioritized Criteria for Receiving a Regular Diploma

Distance from Criteria for Students Without Disabilities	Criteria for Students Partiicpating in the AA-AAS
Exactly the Same	Meet exactly the same state criteria as other students
↓	Meet local district requirements
↓	Meet exactly the same state criteria as other students, with variation for the test requirement
↓	Receive a proficient score on the AA-AAS
↓	Meet other alternative state criteria (e.g., special course of study)
Farthest Away	Meet IEP-defined requirements

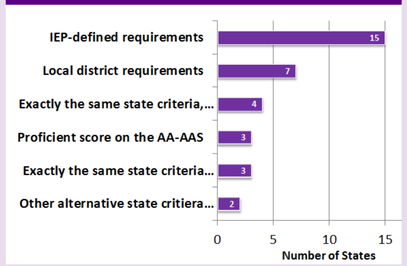
Findings

- Nearly 70% of states allowed students in AA-AAS to receive a regular diploma, but criteria varied widely across states.
- Only one state did not offer a regular diploma or any other end-of-school document to these students.
- Most states had one or more other end-of-school documents (e.g., Certificates of Achievement or Attendance, Special Diploma).
- Some states' requirements for students who participate in the AA-AAS were identical to all other students earning a regular diploma, while other states had very different criteria.

Percent of States that Allow and Do Not AllowStudents in AA-AAS to Receive Regular Diploma

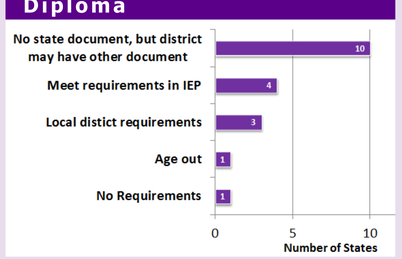


Criteria for Students in AA-AAS to Earn a Regular Diploma

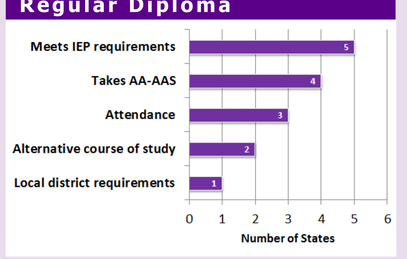


Criteria for Other End-of-School Documents

States that Allow a Regular Diploma



States that Did Not Allow a Regular Diploma



Discussion Points

- Some district-level policies seem to contradict state policies to some degree.
- More than one state that allowed participants in AA-AAS to receive a regular diploma said it rarely happened.
- The difficulty in finding information for this study suggests it would be difficult for parents or educators to determine the graduation criteria.
- A few states notified parents about possible ineligibility for a regular diploma if their child participated in AA-AAS.
- Information on how students in AA-AAS count toward state graduation rates was minimal.

Recommendations

- Policies are needed that ensure students with significant cognitive disabilities are in classes that promote high expectations based on college- and career-ready standards.
- Involve stakeholders (educators, parents, postsecondary education programs and employers) in discussions of ways to recognize successful completion of an educational program based on college- and career-ready standards for students who participate in AA-AAS, and address the meaning of various diploma options.

For More Information

The interactive report can be found at: **http://z.umn.edu/ukz**

The full report may be found at: **http://z.umn.edu/uky**

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